

SEVEN CITIES OF MARS
— Book Two —

The City of SILENCE

BRIAN KEITH ANDERSON

The City of Silence

Book Two of the Seven Cities of Mars

by

Brian Keith Anderson

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Dedication

For those who listened
when nothing answered—
and remained anyway.

The Seven Cities of Mars Series:

- The City of Enduring Light
- The City of Silence
- The City of Flowing Currents
- The City of Restraint
- The City of Passage
- The City of Interconnection
- The City of the Seventh Heart

Epigraph

The first city was remembered.

The second must be heard.

Preface

The second city does not answer.

This is not because it does not hear.

It is because not all things are meant to be
answered at once.

You have come from a place where
something responded.

Where presence was met.

Where endurance revealed itself.

This will not be the same.

You will not be guided in the same way.

You will not be shown what you expect
to see.

You may not even know when you have
been heard.

That is the nature of silence.

It does not confirm.

It does not correct.

It does not reveal itself easily.

And yet—

nothing within it is empty.

If you remain...

if you listen...

if you do not turn away—

you may begin to understand

what silence has been holding

all along.

Chapter One

Where Silence Holds

The land did not change.

That was the first thing he noticed.

After the movement between the Cities—
after the current had carried him beyond
the place where endurance had first been
met—he had expected something to shift.

A sign. A difference. Some trace that
what lay ahead was not the same.

But the ground remained as it was.

Stone. Dust. Distance.

Unanswered.

Asa stood at the edge of it, saying
nothing.

Behind him, far enough now that it could
no longer be felt in full, the Bog of
Enduring Light continued its quiet
rhythm. He did not turn to look at it. He
did not need to.

It was no longer something he stood
within.

It was something he carried.

The bees had not followed.

That, too, was different.

Where once their presence had marked
the path—moving in gentle arcs, bridging
what could not be seen—now there was
only stillness around him. No motion. No
hum. No soft alignment in the air.

Only the land.

And whatever lay within it.

He stepped forward.

The ground did not respond.

It did not resist.

It did not acknowledge him at all.

His foot settled against the surface with the same weight it would have held anywhere else. No shift. No answering tone. No quiet deepening beneath it.

Nothing.

Asa paused.

Not because he needed to.

Because there was nothing to guide the next step.

He had learned to follow what met him.

Here—

nothing met him.

He took another step.

The silence did not change.

It did not thin or deepen. It did not stretch
or pull. It did not gather around him as
the first City had, nor did it press against
him as the second had begun to do.

It remained.

Complete in itself.

Unmoved by his presence.

Asa drew a slow breath.

“This is it,” he said quietly.

Not as certainty.

As recognition.

The words did not carry.

They did not echo. They did not settle
into the land.

They simply ended.

He waited.

Not for an answer.

For anything.

Time passed—though it did not feel the same as before. There was no rhythm to mark it, no pulse beneath the surface to hold it in place. It moved without measure, slipping forward without resistance, leaving nothing behind to define where it had been.

Asa closed his eyes.

Not to reach.

To listen.

At first, there was only the absence of
sound.

No wind.

No movement.

No distant hum of life beneath the
surface.

Nothing.

And yet—

it was not empty.

The longer he remained, the more that
absence began to take form—not as

presence, not as sensation, but as
something that did not need either to
exist.

A stillness that did not belong to the land.

It did not press against him.

It did not draw him in.

It did not even acknowledge that he was
there.

It simply was.

Asa's breath slowed.

He did not try to deepen it.

He did not try to match it.

Because there was nothing to match.

That was the difference.

The first City had recognized him.

The second had measured him.

This—

did neither.

He opened his eyes.

The horizon had not shifted. The long
stretch of stone and dust remained
unchanged, reaching outward in every

direction without variation, without
feature, without sign.

And yet—

he did not feel alone.

Not in the way he understood before.

There was no presence surrounding him.

No awareness watching from beneath.

No sense of something waiting to
respond.

But the silence itself—

held.

“Thank you for reading this sample”